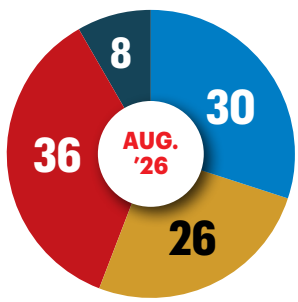
Q. Should India begin a limited dialogue with Pakistan on terrorism, water and trade?



Over half favour limited talks with or without pre-conditions. A substantial minority oppose talks

Q. How do you rate the handling of fuel prices and energy security during the 2026 Iran conflict and disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz?



Over a third think fuel prices were poorly managed, but this is closely followed by the number who say the opposite

All figures in % and rounded off; DK/ CS: Don't know/ can't say



DANGER STILL PRESENT A Thailand-flagged bulk carrier catches fire after it was hit by a missile in the Strait of Hormuz, Mar. 11

AP

56 PER CENT feel that India's handling of fuel prices during the Iran conflict was 'good' or average

talks in Beijing. The meeting comes weeks before India hosts the BRICS Summit in New Delhi on September 12-13, where Chinese president Xi Jinping is expected to visit. It indicates that New Delhi is willing to engage with Beijing, but on the condition that peace and stability on the LAC (Line of Actual Control) remain the foundation for normal ties. Moreover, China is now India's largest trading partner, with bilateral trade worth around $151 billion (Rs 14.4 lakh crore) in FY 2025-26. However, the trade deficit in China's favour is a staggering $112.6 billion (Rs 10.8 lakh crore). Therefore, when asked about the best approach towards China, 24 per cent respondents advocate maintaining economic ties while holding dialogue. This is set against 26 per cent who want India to reduce its economic dependence on China. Around 13 per cent sought a political settlement and 20 per cent favour strengthening military deterrence against the PLA.

LIMITED TALKS WITH PAK

India-Pakistan relations remain on a razor's edge after Operation Sindoor in May 2025, which signalled India's new doctrine that terror attacks would invite calibrated military action. Underlying tensions remain unresolved—the old blight of terrorism, the suspended Indus Waters Treaty and deep diplomatic mistrust. Asked if India should begin a limited dialogue with Pakistan on terrorism, water and trade, over 24 per cent of MOTN respondents say 'Yes, without preconditions', closely followed by 23 per cent who want limited talks only after verifiable action against terrorist groups and 16 per cent who favour talks only through military officials and diplomats. But 22 per cent of respondents are dead against any dialogue at present.

The closure of the Strait of Hormuz during the Iran conflict drove up energy costs and exposed India's vulnerability to geopolitical shocks. It led to the decision to diversify supplies and make energy security a pillar of India's strategic resilience. On the question of the handling of fuel prices and energy security during the continuing crisis, 30 per cent of respondents believe New Delhi has handled the matter well under difficult circumstances. It was 'average', according to 26 per cent, for prices rose but supplies were managed. Significantly, 35 per cent say the issue was 'poorly handled'.

For the Modi government, the challenge is no longer to achieve a balance through its ties with the world's rival blocs, but to ensure that India's strategic manoeuvring delivers stability and prosperity at home. ■